

YEH DOSTI... Amitabh-Dharmendra gave Bollywood its iconic bromance



"As they used to say about the British Empire, the sun never sets on *Sholay*"

— SHYAM SHROFF
Film distributor

THE ORIGINAL BLOCKBUSTER

» **Amitabh Bachchan becomes an invincible force in Hindi cinema for well over a decade. Earns the tag of "one-man industry" after an INDIA TODAY cover story**

» **Bollywood kept trying to repeat *Sholay* with numerous big-budget multi-starrers and imitation revenge dramas**

» **But the film that finally broke its record, becoming the highest grosser, was a fun musical romance: *Hum Aapke Hain Koun..!* (1995)**

» **Aamir, Salman and Shah Rukh Khan gradually took over the mantle as superstars, box-office kings whose very name guaranteed big openings. The sun has yet to set on their supremacy**

» **In 2015, S.S. Rajamouli's *Baahubali: The Beginning* inaugurated a new kind of blockbuster phenomenon: the pan-India hit. Conceived and executed in the South, dubbed versions captured audiences everywhere**

atop the saddles of this dizzily revolving fairground merry-go-round was a real human panorama. The characters were endearing and attractive while being gritty as granite. The landscape charred by gunsmoke also exploded with laughter. And there was Gabbar Singh, a descent into the unknown. Nobody had seen evil quite like it. *Sholay* began speaking to the audiences. And soon enough, the audiences began speaking *Sholay*! Literally, parroting the Salim-Javed lines.

The rest of the story is well-known. *Kitne aadmi thhe*? How many were there, asked the baddie. Well, hundreds of millions, over the years, at cinema halls in India and abroad. Even as far back as 1985, INDIA TODAY had estimated a gross audience of 250 million. Takehome? Fully Rs 35 crore! This was hardly the first time Bollywood had seen a film that kept growing bigger, from conception, to execution, to collections. Even if you leave aside earlier prototypes of the blockbuster phenomenon that presaged *Sholay*'s famous five-year run at Bombay's Minerva theatre, canonical hits like *Mother India* (1957) and *Mughal-e-Azam* (1960) had entrenched the idea of big-budget, ensemble-cast marquee madness. But *Sholay* was a Big Bang that created a quantum universe all its own—as intimate as it was epic, as unique in its internal combustion as it was a collage of borrowed memes, and impossible to recreate as a magic trick even as its tropes got repeated. Again, and again, forever.

Galloping in on the heels of *Deewaar*, his other defining 1975 film, *Sholay* also confirmed we had a superstar like none before in Amitabh Bachchan. His era as absolute sovereign lasted a decade. Even so, he remained the most enduring guarantor of success in countless two-hero and ensemble outings. The big-budget multi-starrer format was itself attempted numerous times, sometimes meeting with success, sometimes not. Think Amitabh's own *Amar Akbar Anthony*, *Shaan* and *Naseeb*, or contemporaneous fare like *The Burning Train*, not to speak of a string of imitation Sholays, all the way from *Loha* and *Yoshilaay* in the '80s to *China Gate* around the turn of the millennium,

DID YOU KNOW?

Two weeks before the first shooting schedule, Danny Denzongpa, the original Gabbar, opted out, citing date problems. Within days, Amjad Khan was tested and hired at Rs 500 a week. So iconic was Gabbar that audio cassettes featuring his dialogues were in heavy demand and Khan was hired to reprise the character in a memorable Parle-G biscuit commercial